

Chapter Summary

Toba Tek Singh by Saadat Hasan Manto is a poignant short story set two to three years after the 1947 Partition of India, when the governments of India and Pakistan decided to exchange lunatics, just as they had exchanged prisoners. The Muslim lunatics in India were to be sent to Pakistan, and the Hindu and Sikh lunatics in Pakistan were to be transferred to India. The story is set in a mental asylum in Lahore, where the inmates, already confused about their surroundings, struggle to understand the concept of Pakistan and India.

The central character, Bishan Singh, is a Sikh inmate who is obsessed with finding out where his hometown, Toba Tek Singh, is located—whether it is in India or Pakistan. He asks everyone but receives no clear answer, as the other inmates are equally confused by the political changes. Bishan Singh, who has been in the asylum for 15 years and has not seen his family for a long time, remains fixated on the question.

When the day of the exchange arrives, the lunatics are brought to the Wagah border. Bishan Singh, however, refuses to cross to either side, declaring that he will not move until he knows where Toba Tek Singh is. Despite efforts to move him, he stands firm in "no man's land," the strip of land between India and Pakistan. In the end, Bishan Singh collapses and dies on this undefined piece of earth, symbolizing the fate of many who were displaced or lost due to the Partition.

The story serves as a powerful critique of the Partition, using madness to highlight the irrationality of dividing a nation and the human cost of political decisions.